

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Math	Advanced Math	Nonlinear equations in one variable and systems of equations in two variables	Medium

Question

$-4x^2 - 7x = -36$

What is the positive solution to the given equation?

Answer

- A. $\frac{7}{4}$
- B. $\frac{9}{4}$
- C. 4
- D. 7

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is correct. Multiplying each side of the given equation by -16 yields $64x^2 + 112x = 576$. To complete the square, adding 49 to each side of this equation yields $64x^2 + 112x + 49 = 576 + 49$, or $(8x + 7)^2 = 625$. Taking the square root of each side of this equation yields two equations: $8x + 7 = 25$ and $8x + 7 = -25$. Subtracting 7 from each side of the equation $8x + 7 = 25$ yields $8x = 18$. Dividing each side of this equation by 8 yields $x = \frac{18}{8}$, or $x = \frac{9}{4}$. Therefore, $\frac{9}{4}$ is a solution to the given equation. Subtracting 7 from each side of the equation $8x + 7 = -25$ yields $8x = -32$. Dividing each side of this equation by 8 yields $x = -4$. Therefore, the given equation has two solutions, $\frac{9}{4}$ and -4 . Since $\frac{9}{4}$ is positive, it follows that $\frac{9}{4}$ is the positive solution to the given equation.

Alternate approach: Adding $4x^2$ and $7x$ to each side of the given equation yields $0 = 4x^2 + 7x - 36$. The right-hand side of this equation can be rewritten as $4x^2 + 16x - 9x - 36$. Factoring out the common factor of $4x$ from the first two terms of this expression and the common factor of -9 from the second two terms yields $4x(x + 4) - 9(x + 4)$. Factoring out the common factor of $(x + 4)$ from these two terms yields the expression $(4x - 9)(x + 4)$. Since this expression is equal to 0 , it follows that either $4x - 9 = 0$ or $x + 4 = 0$. Adding 9 to each side of the equation $4x - 9 = 0$ yields $4x = 9$. Dividing each side of this equation by 4 yields $x = \frac{9}{4}$. Therefore, $\frac{9}{4}$ is a positive solution to the given equation. Subtracting 4 from each side of the equation $x + 4 = 0$ yields $x = -4$. Therefore, the given equation has two solutions, $\frac{9}{4}$ and -4 . Since $\frac{9}{4}$ is positive, it follows that $\frac{9}{4}$ is the positive solution to the given equation.

Choice A is incorrect. Substituting $\frac{7}{4}$ for x in the given equation yields $-\frac{49}{2} = -36$, which is false.

Choice C is incorrect. Substituting 4 for x in the given equation yields $-92 = -36$, which is false.

Choice D is incorrect. Substituting 7 for x in the given equation yields $-245 = -36$, which is false.